

Reptiles

With their scaly skin, reptiles thrive in places with hot, dry climates, although they live in many other habitats as well. There are about 8,000 species. Most of them breed by laying eggs, but some produce live young.

Tuataras

Living only in New Zealand, tuataras belong to an ancient group of reptiles. Instead of true teeth, they have a jagged edge to their jaw.



Both sexes of tuatara have a spiny crest. They grow very slowly and may live for more than 100 years.

Turtles and tortoises

Recognizable by their shells, or carapaces, most animals in this group are turtles. The tortoises form a single land-based family.



With a shell up to 4 ft (1.2 m) long, these Galápagos giant tortoises are among the largest animals in the tortoise family.

Like other sea turtles, the green turtle is streamlined, with winglike front flippers.



The Indian star tortoise's shell becomes increasingly knobby with age and has distinctive starlike markings.



The matamora is a camouflaged river turtle that ambushes prey, sucking fish into its mouth.

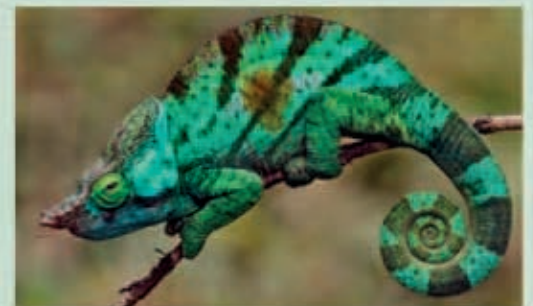


The enormous leatherback turtle has a rubbery carapace up to 6 ft (1.8 m) long and can weigh nearly a ton.

Lizards and snakes

By far the most common reptiles, lizards and snakes are close relatives and form a single group. Snakes are always carnivorous, and most lizards are as well, although some kinds eat plants or animal remains. The majority lay eggs, but in cold regions, many give birth to live young.

Iguanas are plant-eating, tree-dwelling lizards. Their long claws help them to climb, and the males of some species attract females by displaying a fleshy dewlap hanging from their necks.



Chameleons are slow-moving tree-dwellers with grasping feet and swiveling eyes. They are capable of rapid color change.



The Gila monster's colorful patterning warns predators that it is one of very few venomous lizards.



Venomous coral snakes show bright warning colors. Some nonvenomous snakes mimic their pattern.

